Lesson 5 — The Two O'Clock Class

Level: A2+ → B1 (fifth step)

Theme: Teaching computers, volunteering and small steady progress

Time: 6 sessions, 50–60 minutes each

Skills: Listening → Reading → Vocabulary → Grammar → Comprehension → Speaking → Writing

New in this lesson: the present perfect continuous with for and since, the -ing ending and the weak been, a longer passage of 481 words, and the last new question type: the writer's attitude. The comprehension set reaches ten questions, the size of a real TOEFL set.

01 · Passage — The Two O'Clock Class

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-ing-and-been.mp3` is new — the -ing ending and the weak been.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. What have you been learning for a long time?
2. Is there something you do at the same time every week?
3. Who taught you to use a computer, and how?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Two O'Clock Class (481 words)

Rana is twenty-six, and for the last eighteen months she has been teaching a free computer class for children. It happens in one room above her father's shop, and it starts at two o'clock every Saturday.

[A] She is not a teacher. She studied accounting, and she works in an office four days a week. But three years ago she watched a boy in the market trying to fill in a form on a borrowed phone, typing with one finger, and she could not stop thinking about it.

The class has eleven children in it now. Most of them are beginners. They have been learning the same small things, again and again: how to hold a mouse, how to click once and not twice, where the letters are on the keyboard, how to save a file before the power goes.

[B] The electricity comes for about six hours a day, and nobody knows which six. So Rana keeps a timetable on the wall, and ignores it when she has to. The two laptops in the room are old. One of them has a battery that lasts forty minutes; the other has none at all, and it stops the moment the power stops.

Her brother has been repairing those two laptops since the class began. He works in a phone shop six days a week, and he comes here on the seventh. He is patient in a way that Rana says she is not. He has installed the same program four times on the same machine, because a child deleted it four times, and he has never once sounded angry about it.

[C] The children are getting faster. Six months ago most of them typed with one finger, like the boy in the market. Now four of them type without looking down, and one girl, who is nine, has been teaching her own mother in the evenings. Two of them have been coming since the first Saturday and have not missed one.

Rana has been keeping a list since the first Saturday. It has one line for each child: what they can do, and what they are still finding hard. She has not shown it to anyone. It is four pages long now.

[D] People ask her how long she will go on with it. She says she does not know, and that it is not really the right question. The right question, she says, is what a child can do at the end of a year that she could not do at the beginning. For that, the list on her desk already has an answer.

She has been doing this for eighteen months, and she has never asked anyone for money. In that time the class has lost four children and gained seven. The room still has two old laptops. The electricity still comes for six hours a day, and still nobody knows which six.

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. This is the longest passage so far: see whether you can keep going to the end without stopping.

02 · Listening questions

1.2 Listening — first time (no text)

L1. Who is the story about, and what has she been doing?

L2. How long has she been doing it?

L3. What time does the class start, and on which day?

L4. Who repairs the two laptops?

1.3 Listening — second time (no text)

Write four verbs in the present perfect continuous that you heard (has or have + been + -ing).
Then write one word you heard but did not understand.

03 · Vocabulary and Lesson 3 recall

2.1 Key words

#	WORD	TYPE	SIMPLE MEANING	ARABIC	EXAMPLE
1	keyboard	noun	the part with all the letters on it	لوحة المفاتيح	They learn where the letters are on the keyboard.
2	type	verb	to write using a keyboard	يكتب على لوحة المفاتيح	Four of them type without looking down.
3	mouse	noun	the thing you move to point at the screen	فأرة	They learn how to hold a mouse.
4	click	verb	to press the button on a mouse	ينقر	How to click once and not twice.
5	install	verb	to put a program onto a computer	يثبّت	He has installed the same program four times.
6	program	noun	something a computer runs to do a job	برنامج	A child deleted the program.
7	delete	verb	to remove something from a computer	يحذف	A child deleted it four times.
8	beginner	noun	a person who has just started to learn	مبتدئ	Most of them are beginners.
9	patient	adjective	able to wait without getting angry	صبور	He is patient in a way that Rana is not.
10	repair	verb	to mend something that is broken	يصلح	Her brother has been repairing the laptops.
11	battery	noun	the part that holds power inside a machine	بطارية	One laptop has a battery that lasts forty minutes.
12	timetable	noun	a list of what happens at what time	جدول زمني	Rana keeps a timetable on the wall.
13	skill	noun	something you can do well because you learned it	مهارة	Typing is a skill.
14	improve	verb	to get better	يتحسّن	The children improve every month.

2.2 Synonyms and opposites

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
repair	mend, fix	break
patient	calm	impatient

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
improve	get better	get worse
beginner	a new learner	expert
delete	remove	keep
old	not new	new
free	costing nothing	expensive
begin	start	finish / end

2.3 Expressions to learn

EXPRESSION	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS
again and again	many times, without stopping
for the last eighteen months	from eighteen months ago until now
since the class began	from that moment until now
one finger at a time	slowly, the way a beginner types
without looking down	without looking at the keyboard
the moment the power stops	at exactly that second
go on with it	continue doing it

2.4 Vocabulary practice

A. Write the opposite:

1. patient → _____
2. improve → _____
3. delete → _____
4. beginner → _____
5. repair → _____

B. Which word is different? Say why:

1. mouse — keyboard — battery — timetable
2. install — delete — repair — patient
3. beginner — child — mother — program

C. Say it in your own words:

1. What is a beginner?
2. What does patient mean?

04 · Grammar — the present perfect continuous

Come back to: the present simple

Lesson 1 taught the shape and Lesson 2 added where frequency words go. Two lines to remind you:

I / YOU / WE / THEY	WORK
he / she / it	works

New this time: the present simple is not only for habits.

It is also the tense for a timetable or a fixed arrangement:

> The class starts at two o'clock every Saturday.
> The centre opens at nine and closes at four.

And for something that is simply true, with no time attached:

> The electricity comes for about six hours a day.
> Water boils at one hundred degrees.

Look at the first one again. The class starts at two is not a habit at all — it is the timetable, and it can even point at a fixed event in the future (the exam starts on Monday). Arabic would often reach for a future form there. English does not.

Quick practice. Present simple, or present perfect continuous?

1. The class _____ (start) at two o'clock every Saturday.
2. She _____ (teach) the class for eighteen months.
3. The electricity _____ (come) for six hours a day.
4. Her brother _____ (repair) the laptops since the class began.

We use the present perfect continuous for something that started in the past, has gone on for a length of time, and is still going on now: She has been teaching the class for eighteen months — and she is teaching it still.

3.1 How we make it

have / has + been + verb -ing

PERSON	PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS
I / you / we / they	have been working
he / she / it	has been working

3.2 What we use it for

How long something has been going on: He has been repairing those laptops since the class began.

An action that is still happening now: She has been keeping a list since the first Saturday.

Something repeated again and again over a period: They have been learning the same small things.

It almost always comes with for or since, or a phrase like all year, again and again, for the last eighteen months.

3.4 Present perfect, or present perfect continuous?

PRESENT PERFECT — THE RESULT, HOW MANY	PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS — THE ACTIVITY, HOW LONG
He has installed the program four times.	He has been repairing the laptops for a year.
She has not shown the list to anyone.	She has been keeping the list since the first Saturday.
The class has lost four children.	She has been doing this for eighteen months.

A short way to hold it: the simple one counts how many, the continuous one measures how long.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	have not / has not been + -ing	She has not been teaching this year.
Question	Have / Has + person + been + -ing	How long has she been teaching?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the present perfect continuous:

1. Rana _____ (teach) the class for eighteen months.
2. The children _____ (learn) the same small things.
3. Her brother _____ (repair) the laptops since the class began.
4. One girl _____ (teach) her own mother in the evenings.
5. _____ how long _____ you _____ (study) English?

B. Simple or continuous?

1. He (has installed / has been installing) the program four times.
2. She (has kept / has been keeping) the list since the first Saturday.
3. The class (has lost / has been losing) four children.
4. They (have learned / have been learning) the same things again and again.

C. Write for or since:

1. ____ eighteen months
2. ____ the class began
3. ____ the first Saturday

4. ____ three years

05 · The -ing ending and been

3.3 The -ing ending, and been (listen to `05-ing-and-been.mp3`)

This tense is three small words joined together, and all three of them shrink in speech. If you cannot hear them, you cannot hear the tense.

1. -ing ends with one sound, not two.

SPELLING	SOUND	NOT THIS
working	/ˈwɜːkɪŋ/	/ˈwɜːkɪn/
teaching	/ˈtiːtʃɪŋ/	/ˈtiːtʃɪn/
learning	/ˈlɜːnɪŋ/	/ˈlɜːnɪn/
repairing	/rɪˈpeərɪŋ/	/rɪˈpeərɪn/
keeping	/ˈkiːpɪŋ/	/ˈkiːpɪn/

The last sound is /ŋ/, made at the back of the mouth with the tongue down. There is no /g/ after it, and it is not /n/ at the front of the mouth.

2. been is weak.

Inside the tense, been is short and quiet: /bɪn/, not /biːn/.

WRITTEN	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HEAR
She has been working.	/ʃiːz bɪn ˈwɜːkɪŋ/
They have been learning.	/ðeɪv bɪn ˈlɜːnɪŋ/
He has been repairing it.	/hiːz bɪn rɪˈpeərɪŋ ɪt/

So has been working can arrive as one short run of sound. In the audio you hear each one twice, and then a test: say whether what you hear is finished or still going.

06 · Comprehension — a full TOEFL set of ten

Part A — Multiple choice

> This is a full set of ten, the size of a real TOEFL reading set.

1. (Factual) What did Rana study?

   A. Teaching.
   B. Accounting.
   C. Computers.
   D. The passage does not say.

2. (Factual) How long has Rana been teaching the class?

   A. Six months.
   B. Eighteen months.
   C. Three years.
   D. Forty minutes.

3. (Negative factual) According to the passage, the children have been learning all of the following EXCEPT

   A. how to hold a mouse.
   B. where the letters are on the keyboard.
   C. how to repair a laptop.
   D. how to save a file before the power goes.

4. (Vocabulary in context) The word "ignores" in the passage is closest in meaning to

   A. takes no notice of.
   B. writes down.
   C. repairs.
   D. reads aloud.

5. (Reference) In the sentence, the other has none at all, the word "none" refers to

   A. no laptop.
   B. no battery.
   C. no child.
   D. no power cut.

6. (Inference) It can be inferred from the passage that

   A. Rana plans to stop the class soon.
   B. Rana measures the class by what the children can do, not by how long it has run.

C. the children's parents pay for the class.

D. her brother was trained to repair computers.

7. (Sentence insertion) Look at the four letters [A] [B] [C] [D] in the passage. Where would this sentence best fit?

> Nothing in the room can be relied on.

- A. At [A]
- B. At [B]
- C. At [C]
- D. At [D]

8. (Purpose of a paragraph) Why does the writer mention the boy in the market?

A. To show that Rana is a trained teacher.

B. To explain what made Rana start the class.

C. To criticise the schools in the area.

D. To show that phones are difficult to use.

9. (Purpose of the whole passage) What is the writer's main purpose in the whole passage?

A. To explain how to teach children to type.

B. To describe how one person has kept a small class going, and what it has produced.

C. To ask the reader for money for the class.

D. To compare two kinds of laptop.

10. (The writer's attitude — NEW) Which word best describes the writer's attitude towards Rana?

A. Amused.

B. Doubtful.

C. Respectful.

D. Uninterested.

Part C — Fill in the blanks

Use these words. There are two extra words you will not need.

> beginners · keyboard · battery · timetable · repairs · installed · patient · volunteer · skill

1. Most of the children are _____.
2. They are learning where the letters are on the _____.
3. One laptop has a _____ that lasts forty minutes.
4. Rana keeps a _____ on the wall.
5. Her brother _____ the two laptops.
6. He has _____ the same program four times.

7. He is very _____.

Part D — Summary

Write the story in two sentences only. Use the present perfect continuous once.

> Sentence 1 — what Rana has been doing: _____ Sentence 2 — what has changed for the children: _____

07 · True / false

Part B — True / False

Write T or F. If it is false, write the correct sentence.

1. Rana trained as a teacher. ____
2. The class starts at two o'clock on Saturdays. ____
3. Both laptops have working batteries. ____
4. Her brother has been repairing the laptops since the class began. ____
5. Rana has shown her list to the children's parents. ____
6. The class has more children now than when it began. ____

08 · Speaking

5.1 Speaking (record each answer, 45 seconds)

1. Tell the story of Rana in your own words. Use for, since, and has been doing.
2. What have you been learning or practising for a long time? How long have you been doing it?
3. Describe something you do at a fixed time every week. What time does it start, and what happens?

Useful sentence starters:

I have been ____ing for ____ years.

I have been doing it since ____.

It starts at ____ o'clock every ____.

At first I could not ____, and now I can ____.

I have not finished yet, because ____.

09 · Writing — Something I Have Been Doing for a Long Time

5.2 Writing — "Something I Have Been Doing for a Long Time" (14–16 sentences)

Model answer (copy the shape, change the words):

> I have been studying English for four years, and I have been doing it almost entirely alone. My class at school finished when I was seventeen. Since then I have been using free videos and a small notebook. I write every new word in it, and I read the old pages on Fridays. The notebook is a timetable of a kind: it tells me what I have been forgetting. For the last eight months I have also been writing one short text every week. At first they were four sentences long and full of tense mistakes. They are longer now, and the mistakes have changed, which my teacher says is a good sign. I have not become fluent, and I do not expect to this year. But I have been improving in a way I can measure, because the notebook keeps the evidence. The class I take online starts at seven o'clock every Tuesday. I have missed it twice in eight months. That is the part I am most pleased about.

Checklist before you send it:

- [ ] I used the present perfect continuous at least four times.
- [ ] I used the present simple for a timetable or something simply true.
- [ ] I used for with a length of time and since with a point in time.
- [ ] I used the present perfect simple at least once for how many.
- [ ] I used at least 5 new words from Session 2.
- [ ] I used at least 2 words from Lesson 3 or Lesson 4.
- [ ] My text has 14–16 sentences.

10 · Review

6.1 Listen again (no text)

1. Name three things the children have been learning.
2. What does Rana say is the right question to ask about the class?

6.2 Mini-quiz (12 marks)

1. The present perfect continuous of work, for she, is _____
2. We use ____ with a length of time and ____ with a point in time. (for / since) _____
3. Which one counts how many: the simple or the continuous? _____
4. The opposite of patient is _____
5. The opposite of improve is _____
6. A person who has just started to learn is a _____
7. To put a program onto a computer is to _____
8. The part that holds power inside a machine is a _____
9. Write a sentence with since and the present perfect continuous.
10. Write a question beginning How long.
11. Write one sentence with timetable.
12. Tell the story of the passage in two sentences, from memory.

6.3 Lesson 5 self-report

QUESTION	ANSWER
Minutes studied this week	
Hardest part (listening / reading / vocabulary / grammar / speaking / writing)	
Present-perfect-continuous sentences I can now make without thinking	
Words from Lesson 3 I have forgotten	
One thing I want to repeat next week	

11 · Answer key and teacher notes

Listening: L1 — Rana; she has been teaching a free computer class for children · L2 — for eighteen months · L3 — two o'clock, every Saturday · L4 — her brother

Part A (MCQ): 1-B · 2-B · 3-C · 4-A · 5-B · 6-B · 7-B · 8-B · 9-B · 10-C

Why 7 is [B]: the sentence is about things that cannot be depended on, and only the paragraph after [B]** is about unreliable things — six hours of electricity nobody can predict, one dead battery, one laptop that stops the moment the power does.

Why 8 is [B]**: the boy in the market is the reason the class exists. He is not evidence about schools, and the paragraph is not about phones.

Why 9 is [B]**: the passage gives no instructions and asks for nothing. It follows one person over eighteen months and ends on what the children can now do.

Why 10 is C, respectful: the writer never praises Rana directly — there is no "wonderful", no "heroic". Instead the admiration is carried by what is chosen and reported: the brother who never once sounded angry, the list she has shown to nobody, the last paragraph that refuses a neat ending. Watch for this: in TOEFL, attitude is almost always shown by selection of detail**, not by adjectives.

Part B (True/False):

1. F — She studied accounting.
2. T
3. F — One has a battery that lasts forty minutes; the other has none.
4. T
5. F — She has not shown it to anyone.
6. T — It has lost four and gained seven.

Part C (Fill in the blanks): 1. beginners · 2. keyboard · 3. battery · 4. timetable · 5. repairs · 6. installed · 7. patient (Extra words: volunteer, skill)

2.4 A (Opposites): 1. impatient · 2. get worse · 3. keep · 4. expert · 5. break

2.4 B (Odd one out): 1. timetable (the others are parts of a machine) · 2. patient (the others are things you do to a computer) · 3. program (the others are people)

Come back to (present simple or continuous): 1. starts · 2. has been teaching · 3. comes · 4. has been repairing

3.6 A (Present perfect continuous): 1. has been teaching · 2. have been learning · 3. has been repairing · 4. has been teaching · 5. How long have … been studying 3.6 B (Simple or continuous): 1. has installed · 2. has been keeping · 3. has lost · 4. have been learning 3.6 C (for / since): 1. for · 2. since · 3. since · 4. for

Mini-quiz: 1. she has been working · 2. for, since · 3. the simple · 4. impatient · 5. get worse · 6. beginner · 7. install · 8. battery · 9–12. teacher judgement

Teacher Notes

What changed from Lesson 4. The passage grew from 400 to 481 words, the present perfect continuous joins the present perfect, and the comprehension set reaches ten questions — the size of a real TOEFL reading set, and the first time the course has given her a full one. The tenth type, the writer's attitude, is the last of the set; from here nothing new is added and only the text gets harder, which was the promise made in Lesson 1.

The one real difficulty. Not the form, which is mechanical, but knowing when has done will not do. Arabic speakers reach for the simple form for everything, and I have studied English since 2019 is not wrong — it is just weaker than I have been studying. Use 3.4 and 3.6 B: the simple counts how many, the continuous measures how long. If she can say which of those a sentence is doing, she will choose correctly.

Why the pronunciation part is the one to protect. This tense is has + been + -ing, and in speech all three shrink: */ʃiːz bɪn ˈwɜːkɪŋ/*. A student who writes it perfectly can still fail to hear it, and then loses the tense in every conversation. Part 05 is not decoration.

On the "Come back to" section. It takes the present simple, which Lessons 1 and 2 taught as habit, and adds the use that nobody teaches early: timetables and fixed arrangements. The exam starts on Monday is a future event in a present tense, and Arabic would mark the future there. It is a small thing that makes her English sound considerably less translated.

Why this story. Four passages have now been about things going wrong and being recovered. This one is about something slowly going right, and it is the first with a character who is not a student. It also gives the attitude question something to bite on: the admiration in it is never stated, only shown, which is exactly what the new question type tests.

Success criteria for Lesson 5. The student should be able to:

- answer L1–L4 correctly on the second hearing;
- hear she's been working and write it in full;
- form the present perfect continuous and ask How long have you been …?;
- choose correctly between simple and continuous in 3.6 B;
- use the present simple for a timetable without reaching for the future;
- use 10 of the 14 key words in her own sentence;
- write 14 sentences about a long activity with fewer than 4 tense errors.

If it is too easy: Lesson 6 goes to about 550 words and adds the future with will and going to, with no new question type — the set is complete. If it is too hard: keep the same passage for a second week, drop question 10, and drill only the Come back to section and 3.4.

A note on spaced recall. `03-vocabulary.mp3` ends with five Lesson 3 words — server, software, restart, broken, save. Lesson 4 recalled Lesson 2, so the two-lesson gap holds. Lesson 4's words are due back in Lesson 6.